

Cœur—yes, the Chandannagar Sacred Heart Catholic Church—with great pomp and ceremony. The blush-red Rabindranath Tagore statue right across the road certainly didn't seem to mind. Gurudev, rumour has it, wrote parts of *Gitanjali*, his Nobel-winning book of poems, in a house nearby.

Most people think of Lucknow when they hear 'Imambara', but as we sailed upstream, past the former Dutch settlement of Chinsurah, we were told that there was one very close. Raised in 1861 from a hefty sum donated by Haji Muhammad Mohsin, a noble philanthropist of Persian origin, the complex is still impressive—an imposing clock tower and beautiful prayer hall, and courtyard and corridors.

**VIEW FINDER**
(Clockwise from left) Loungers look out to the riparian countryside; the ABN *Rajmahal* passes a number of bridges in the first leg; Nizamat Imambara at the Hazarduari Palace



INDRANEEL MAJUMDAR

## THE BURDEN OF A PRESTIGIOUS LEGACY

Also known as Ambika Kalna, this Purba Bardhaman town, situated on the banks of the Bhagirathi river, is home to the famous Naba Kailash temple complex (built in 1809), where two concentric rings made up of 74 and 34 terracotta shrines (totalling 108, an auspicious figure in Hinduism), respectively, stand testament to the patronage of the Bardhaman royals, in this case, King Tej Chandra Bahadur.

Our shore excursion kicked off with a toto ride from the riverbank, through the markets, towards two temple complexes just across the street from each other. We first went to the Kalna Rajbari, a sprawling collection of royal temples and shrines built during the early 18th century, following it up with a tour of the terracotta temples of Naba Kailash. The real surprise, however, awaited us at Rajib Debnath's muslin-weaving workshop.

The soft-spoken Jamdani artisan has a few hundred weavers employed in the manufacture of these painstakingly produced and, so, heftily priced textiles that fetch lakhs of rupees in the international market—he supplies to couturiers such as Gucci and Chanel and even has weaves displayed at the Victoria Memorial. At the adjoining store, Debnath produced one that was priced at Rs 19 lakh.

Back in my cabin on the cruise, I deposited myself into the window side cane chair to read, as the unrushed riparian landscape—windswept vetiver planted to prevent erosion, jute drying at regular intervals,